The Autogens

A Deconstructed Dwarf Archetype

A deconstructed dwarf archetype for use across fantasy, science fiction, and low- or no-magic settings.

Preamble

Autogens at a Glance

The Autogens are one of several concept-races created by **deconstructing a familiar fantasy archetype**.

They answer the question:

> What makes a dwarf a dwarf if we remove the conventional visual and > cultural baggage?

They deliberately abandon many familiar dwarf traits—beards, mining, underground habitation, axes, Scottish aesthetics, etc.—while retaining a recognizable underlying identity.

The species is designed to function as a playable people in:

- traditional fantasy
- low-magic fantasy
- settings without magic
- science fiction
- realistic or semi-realistic speculative biology

Their defining characteristics should therefore have a **strong biological and cultural foundation**, rather than depending on supernatural abilities.

They should be strange enough to feel genuinely alien, but sufficiently person-like to support ordinary character-driven play.

Core Identity

The Autogens are defined primarily by four concepts:

1. A compact, heavily mineralized body
2. A distributed nervous system
3. A life cycle involving destructive parthenogenetic succession
4. Biological transmission of compressed ancestral memory

Their central philosophical tension is:

An Autogen inherits itself, but is not merely a copy of itself.

A successor inherits the body plan, genetics, some memories, skills, fears, and the wishes of its predecessor, but also spends its youth accumulating experiences of its own.

Thus every succession simultaneously represents:

- continuity
- inheritance
- death
- rebirth
- individuality
- change

Document Structure

The document is divided into three main sections of information, followed by the design material:

- **Biology & Culture** describes the Autogens as a species and people, independently of any particular game system or setting.
- **Storytelling** describes the implications of the species for characters, settings, and play.
- **Designer Notes** collects the unresolved questions and principles that govern the design.

Biology & Culture

Name and Terminology

II.1.1 Autogen

Autogen is the singular common name; **Autogens** is the plural.

The name is inspired by Greek **autogenēs**, meaning approximately **self-produced / self-generated**.

The Greek-derived concept was chosen because it has the desired tonal qualities:

- mundane enough to resemble a scientific or taxonomic term
- fantastic enough to belong naturally in speculative fiction
- intelligible to English-speaking readers
- not tied to conventional dwarf aesthetics

The name emphasizes the species' central philosophical idea:

They produce their successors from themselves.

However, the successor is not a simple clone. It inherits the predecessor while developing independently and being shaped by its own experiences.

II.1.2 Why not "dwarf"?

"Dwarf" is deliberately retained only as the **archetype being deconstructed**, not as the final species name.

There will be multiple races derived from the dwarf archetype, each with its own identity. Calling all of them dwarves would defeat the purpose of the project.

II.1.3 The mnemospore

A **mnemospore** is the biological memory seed produced by an elderly Autogen.

The word combines the Greek-derived concepts of:

- **mnēmē** — memory
- **spore / sporos** — seed

The term was chosen because the memory archive is literally a **seed of ancestral memory** planted into the next generation.

The mnemospore is not magical and is not a literal recording of a brain.

It is a biological information-bearing structure containing a lossy, compressed representation of the elder's significant memories and learned neural patterns.

The exact molecular mechanism is deliberately unspecified. The setting requires a plausible biological principle, not a complete treatise on molecular neuroscience.

II.1.4 Mnemosporan

A **mnemosporan** is an Autogen currently carrying a mnemospore.

This normally applies to:

- an **autogenic youth**, who has inherited a mnemospore but has not opened it
- an **elderly Autogen**, who has produced and sealed their own mnemospore and is awaiting succession

An ordinary mature adult between these stages is **not** a mnemosporan.

The terminology therefore describes a particular biological state rather than an ethnicity or caste.

Body Plan

The Autogen is a **bipedal, bilaterally symmetrical terrestrial organism**.

It remains broadly human-sized and capable of walking on Earth-like planetary surfaces.

However, it is not a modified human.

Its anatomy is based primarily on a **living ossicular skeleton**, inspired by the biomineralized internal structures of echinoderms without making the Autogens echinoderms.

The adult silhouette is deliberately reminiscent of a small living **rock golem**.

This is an aesthetic resemblance only.

Autogens are living organisms composed of:

- flesh
- blood
- living mineralized tissue
- nervous tissue
- muscles
- ossicles
- organs

They are not made of stone.

The Barrel Torso

The central body is a compact, roughly barrel-shaped trunk.

The barrel is unusually rigid.

Its rigidity results from a dense internal lattice of living, biomineralized ossicles.

The torso functions as a major structural unit rather than as a highly flexible human-style spine-and-ribcage assembly.

Consequences include:

- little torso flexion
- little spinal twisting
- poor ability to bend at the waist
- limited ability to contort
- substantial resistance to blunt trauma
- a squat, solid silhouette

An Autogen cannot move its body like a human gymnast.

This is not an incidental limitation: it is a direct consequence of the anatomy and contributes to the species' physical identity.

An Autogen may have difficulty scratching the middle of its own back. This can have mundane social consequences, including reliance on other Autogens or tools for grooming.

Ossicles and Mineralized Skin

The Autogen's body contains extensive **biomineralized ossicles**.

These are living structural tissues rather than inert rocks.

They form a composite material analogous in broad principle to the fracture-resistant ossicles of echinoderms:

- mineral components provide hardness and compressive strength
- organic components provide toughness and resistance to catastrophic fracture
- flexible tissues connect individual structural elements
- living tissues maintain and repair the mineralized structures

The ossicles extend outward into the integument, producing **thick, hardened mineralized skin**.

From a distance, an adult Autogen can therefore resemble a small stone or ceramic statue.

At close range, however, its living nature is obvious:

- plates move against one another
- flexible tissue occupies seams
- muscles move beneath the integument
- the organism breathes
- sensory organs move
- vocal structures vibrate
- blood and living tissue exist beneath the mineralized exterior

The guiding aesthetic is:

> **The Autogen does not wear armor. The Autogen is alive beneath a layer of > living biological armor.**

Joints

The Autogens do not require a human-style skeleton.

Individual ossicles and groups of ossicles can articulate against one another through flexible living tissue.

Major joints are therefore better understood as **regions of articulation and reduced ossicle density** rather than exact analogues of human ball-and-socket or hinge joints.

A limb contains:

- large structural ossicles
- smaller supporting ossicles
- muscles
- connective tissue
- blood vessels
- nerves

Muscles attach to groups of ossicles and move them relative to one another.

This allows the body to retain recognizable limbs while using an essentially different skeletal architecture.

Locomotor Limbs

The two legs attach low on the barrel, somewhat toward its sides.

They are short, thick, and powerful.

The legs are primarily designed for:

- stability
- weight bearing
- pushing
- carrying
- sustained walking

They are not optimized for agility or acrobatics.

The lower limbs terminate in broad, **elephant-like feet**.

The feet provide a large support area, helping compensate for the difficulty of balancing a rigid barrel-shaped body on two legs.

The gait is broadly human-like rather than bird-like.

This was deliberately chosen because the Autogens must remain recognizably bipedal and playable, while a bird-like gait would conflict with their intended visual identity.

Their walking therefore uses alternating legs in a familiar bipedal gait, but with:

- shorter strides
- a relatively wide stance
- reduced pelvic rotation
- little spinal movement
- substantial mechanical stability

The result should look more like a **solid living statue walking with purpose** than an agile humanoid.

Manipulatory Limbs

The two arms attach to the sides of the barrel, relatively high on the body.

They are substantially more mobile than the torso.

The shoulders use deep articulating structures embedded in the ossicular framework.

The arms should have enough mobility for normal character interaction:

- holding weapons
- using tools
- opening doors
- writing
- manipulating objects
- operating machinery
- gesturing

The hands remain relatively familiar in function, because playable characters need to interact with their environments.

The contrast is intentional:

> **The body is a tank; the hands are precision instruments.**

The Sensory Mast

The Autogen does not possess a humanoid head.

Instead, a **sensory mast** rises from the top of the barrel.

The mast contains the principal external sensory and communication organs.

It is not primarily a container for the brain.

The sensory mast may contain:

- visual organs
- olfactory organs
- auditory organs
- other environmental sensors
- sound-producing structures

The structures can move independently or in coordinated patterns.

These movements provide much of the Autogen's equivalent of facial expression.

An Autogen therefore does not smile, frown, or raise an eyebrow.

Instead, emotional states may be expressed through:

- orientation of the sensory mast
- position of sensory organs
- posture
- arm gestures
- changes in organ coloration or reflectivity
- movements of sound-producing structures

To humans these may initially appear strange or ambiguous, but Autogens possess a sophisticated native body language based on them.

Breathing

The upper portion of the barrel contains **bellows-like respiratory organs**.

A respiratory opening is located toward the top of the torso, near the base of the sensory mast.

Air is actively pumped through the respiratory system by muscular bellows rather than by expansion of a flexible ribcage.

The torso can therefore remain largely rigid while the Autogen breathes.

The external signs of breathing may be subtle.

Olfaction

The olfactory organs are located strategically on the sensory mast near the respiratory airflow.

Incoming air passes near or through the olfactory structures, allowing the Autogen to sample its chemical composition.

This provides a simple biological explanation for olfaction without requiring a humanoid nose.

It also reinforces the sensory mast as a functional antenna rather than a disguised head.

Feeding and Digestion

A large **feeding aperture** is located on the torso, approximately in its central/lower region.

It is not a conventional humanoid mouth.

Food is introduced directly into the aperture.

The digestive tract can otherwise remain broadly conventional:

> feeding aperture → esophagus → stomach → intestine → rectum → anus

The anus is located toward the lower/rear region of the body rather than adopting the echinoderm arrangement in which the digestive opening would be positioned in an unusual place.

No exotic digestive system is required.

The barrel-shaped torso provides ample room for the digestive organs.

This is an example of deliberate biological restraint: not every feature needs to be alien simply because the species as a whole is alien.

Vocalization

The Autogen speaks using **external sound-producing organs on the sensory mast**.

These are not necessarily a larynx or a mouth.

They may consist of specialized membranes, resonating structures, and controlled airflow.

The resulting voice is biologically generated and should sound like a real living organism rather than a magical or mechanical effect.

The sound-producing organs are separate from the feeding aperture.

The Distributed Brain

The Autogen possesses a **distributed central nervous system** rather than a single centralized brain.

There are five major neural lobes:

1. left arm lobe
2. right arm lobe
3. left leg lobe
4. right leg lobe
5. sensory/central lobe associated with the sensory mast

These are connected by thick neural pathways running through the torso.

The limbs therefore possess substantial local neural processing.

The Autogen does not consciously control every microscopic component of movement; the limb lobes handle much of the low-level motor processing.

The sensory lobe processes and integrates information from the mast.

The five regions collectively constitute one mind.

The distributed architecture is not intended to make Autogens effectively immortal or allow them to casually survive catastrophic brain injury. Damage to a lobe can cause severe functional impairment; damage to the neural connections can be catastrophic.

The Memory Organ

Autogens possess a specialized **memory organ** associated with the central nervous system.

Its purpose is to convert significant long-term neural information into biological information-bearing material.

During an Autogen's life, specialized **archiver cells** interact with the nervous system.

They preferentially preserve:

- emotionally significant experiences
- repeated activities
- deeply practiced skills
- strong fears
- important habits
- impactful events

The process is deliberately **lossy**.

The memory archive is not a perfect recording of the individual's brain.

Consequently:

- trivial experiences disappear
- details are compressed
- memories become generalized
- old memories lose specificity
- multiple ancient lives gradually blend together

A very old Autogen cannot necessarily distinguish which ancestor experienced a particular event.

It may instead possess a generalized inherited memory such as:

> **"Fire is dangerous."**

rather than a precise recollection of which ancestor suffered a particular burn.

This lossiness is essential to prevent the species from becoming effectively immortal repositories of perfect historical records.

The Mnemospore

When an Autogen reaches elderhood, its memory organ produces a **mnemospore**.

The mnemospore contains the compressed biological information necessary to reconstruct an approximate ancestral neural state in a genetically compatible successor.

It is sealed inside a tough biomineralized shell.

The shell is aesthetically analogous to a pearl, but the structure is entirely biological and specialized.

The mnemospore is simultaneously:

- biological archive
- reproductive inheritance
- physical relic
- sacred object
- symbol of personal continuity

Reproduction and Succession

Autogen reproduction has two complementary modes.

II.16.1 Sexual Reproduction

Autogens reproduce sexually in a conventional, non-destructive manner.

A couple can have multiple children.

The number of offspring is broadly comparable to human reproductive patterns rather than the enormous broods characteristic of many arthropods.

Sexual reproduction provides:

- genetic novelty
- population growth
- resilience
- variation
- a normal family structure

It prevents the species from becoming a closed population of endlessly recycled individuals.

II.16.2 Destructive Parthenogenetic Succession

Every elder Autogen has another reproductive possibility: **succession**.

The elder produces a genetically related successor through a specialized form of destructive parthenogenesis.

The process ultimately kills the parent.

The Juvenile Form

The juvenile Autogen is a smaller, weaker, softer version of the adult.

It is already recognizably the same species and retains the fundamental body plan:

- barrel-like torso
- four limbs
- sensory mast
- bilateral symmetry

However, its ossicles are:

- smaller
- thinner
- less mineralized
- more flexible

This allows growth without requiring the organism to continuously enlarge a fully hardened adult shell.

Juveniles cannot reproduce.

They can nevertheless learn, develop personalities, and accumulate their own experiences.

This is essential.

The successor is not simply a dormant adult waiting to receive memories.

It is a genuine developing individual.

Hardening and Awakening

Once the juvenile reaches approximately adult size, it undergoes a profound biological transition.

This may involve metamorphosis, deep hibernation, or a combination of developmental changes.

The important feature is that the transition marks **true adult maturation**.

During it:

- the ossicles reach their mature mineralization
- the adult body becomes fully hardened
- reproductive capability develops
- the mnemospore becomes activated
- specialized enzymes dissolve its shell
- the inherited memory information is released

The successor awakens as an adult carrying the compressed memories of its predecessor.

The Meaning of Age

Autogen society distinguishes between **biological age** and **successional identity**.

A newly awakened adult may say:

> **"Six and eleven."**

This means:

> **sixth succession; eleven years since awakening.**

The first number identifies the succession count.

The second identifies the number of years since the current awakening.

The first number identifies the succession count.

The second identifies the number of years since the current awakening.

A juvenile who has not yet experienced succession simply says:

> **"I'm eleven."**

A generation-zero Autogen, having no predecessor, might say:

> **"I'm new and eleven."**

This vocabulary reflects their unusual conception of personal continuity.

A human asks:

> **"How old are you?"**

An Autogen may instead be asked:

> **"Which are you, and how long have you been awake?"**

Successional Identity

The new adult is neither simply a new individual nor simply the old individual reborn.

It is a **continuation**.

The inherited memories provide continuity, but the juvenile's independent life provides divergence.

Consequently, successive incarnations of the same lineage can develop:

- different personalities
- different interests
- different political beliefs
- different friendships
- different values

while still feeling genuine continuity with previous selves.

The species therefore has a culturally important distinction between:

> **"the body"**

and

> **"the continuing person."**

An Autogen may meaningfully describe an ancestor as "me," while simultaneously acknowledging that the ancestor was not identical to the current self.

The Elder's Testament

The mnemospore is not the only inheritance.

An elder traditionally leaves a **testament** to the people entrusted with raising their successor.

The testament contains instructions and wishes concerning the successor's upbringing.

These may include:

- education
- skills
- philosophical guidance
- personal hopes
- unfinished obligations
- warnings
- recommendations about interests and vocation

The testament can deliberately contradict the elder's own life.

For example, an engineer might conclude:

> **"I spent too much of my life studying engineering. Make sure my successor > learns music."**

Or:

> **"I wasted my youth on frivolous pursuits. Teach my successor engineering > first."**

The testament represents the elder's **judgment upon their own life**, rather than merely a set of instructions for reproducing themselves.

Custody of the Testament

Being entrusted with another person's testament is one of the highest expressions of friendship and trust in Autogen society.

The custodian is not merely raising a child.

They are entrusted with:

- part of an individual's legacy
- the upbringing of their successor
- the interpretation of their final wishes

- effectively, one half of the mechanism by which that person's continuity becomes possible

The mnemospore represents the biological half of succession.

The testament represents the **social half**.

Together:

> **the mnemospore preserves who the elder was; the testament influences who > the successor becomes.**

Why Society Matters

Destructive succession could theoretically create a solipsistic cycle:

> one individual ⟶ successor ⟶ successor ⟶ successor

The juvenile stage prevents this from becoming socially self-contained.

Someone must:

- raise juveniles
- feed them
- protect them
- educate them
- introduce them to society
- interpret their ancestor's testament
- help them become adults

Sexual reproduction further creates conventional families and social networks.

As a result, Autogen society is not merely a collection of immortal individuals repeatedly respawning themselves.

It is a society containing:

- parents
- children
- siblings
- friends
- elders
- custodians
- successors
- unrelated individuals

The distinction between biological descent and personal continuity can therefore become culturally important.

Failure of Succession

An elder may die without producing a successor.

Reasons may include:

- infertility
- illness
- accident
- failure to reach elderhood
- deliberate refusal
- biological failure

If an elder has already produced a mnemospore but subsequently fails to create a successor, the mnemospore remains as a relic.

It can be preserved and revered.

But it is useless for restoring that individual.

This creates a profound cultural distinction between:

> **memory preserved**

and

> **continuity achieved.**

A preserved mnemospore can prove that someone existed and that they intended to continue.

It cannot by itself make that continuation happen.

The Sacred Quality of the Mnemospore

Although the mnemospore is entirely biological, it naturally acquires religious and ceremonial significance.

It is physically:

- the elder's compressed past
- the seed of the successor
- a tangible object representing continuity

A mnemospore may therefore be treated with extraordinary reverence without requiring the Autogens to have supernatural beliefs.

Different cultures could interpret it:

- religiously
- philosophically
- biologically
- legally
- sentimentally

while all agreeing on its practical importance.

Terminology Summary

Term	Meaning
Autogen	One individual of the species
Autogens	The species as a whole
Autogenesis	The biological process of producing a successor
Succession	The transition from elder to successor
Mnemospore	The mineral-encased biological memory seed
Mnemosporan	An Autogen currently carrying a mnemospore

Elder | An Autogen approaching or undergoing succession | | **Successor** | The juvenile/adult produced by an elder's destructive parthenogenesis | | **Testament** | The elder's instructions and wishes for their successor's upbringing | | **Awakening** | The adult transition during which the mnemospore is opened and inherited memories become accessible |

Storytelling

The Autogens as a Deconstructed Dwarf Archetype

The Autogens deliberately remove familiar dwarf traits:

- beards
- axes
- Scottish aesthetics
- underground habitation
- mining as an innate occupation
- low-light vision
- magical darkvision
- magical tremorsense
- stone flesh
- magical resilience
- supernatural immortality

These traits were discarded because they are consequences of the conventional dwarf archetype rather than fundamental requirements for a dwarf-like species.

Their unusual abilities should instead emerge from their biology.

Sensory Abilities in Play

The Autogens do not inherently require low-light vision.

Likewise, vibration sensing is not intrinsically magical.

If useful for a particular population, vibration sensing could be implemented as a biological sensory system analogous in principle to mechanosensation in real organisms.

However, because the current Autogens are conceived primarily as general-purpose surface dwellers rather than innate subterranean miners, exceptional vibration sensing is **not** a defining species trait.

The same applies to unusually strong low-light vision.

The species' special biology is instead concentrated on:

- mineralized integument
- distributed nervous system
- memory archiving
- mnemospore formation
- destructive succession
- unusual body architecture

The Overall Aesthetic

An adult Autogen should evoke:

> **a small, squat living stone statue.**

But the impression should change dramatically on closer inspection.

At a distance:

- squat
- broad
- heavy
- mineral
- rigid
- almost golem-like

At close range:

- flesh
- blood
- seams
- moving plates
- breathing
- sensory organs adjusting
- vocal membranes vibrating
- living tissue beneath the mineral shell

The visual contradiction is intentional.

They look like something that **should be inanimate**, but clearly are not.

Continuity as a Character Concept

The Autogens' central philosophical tension gives the species a particular way of approaching identity.

A successor inherits the predecessor while developing independently.

The inherited memories provide continuity, but the juvenile's independent life provides divergence.

Successive incarnations of the same lineage can therefore possess different personalities, interests, political beliefs, friendships, and values while still feeling genuine continuity with previous selves.

An Autogen may meaningfully describe an ancestor as "me," while simultaneously acknowledging that the ancestor was not identical to the current self.

The Central Thematic Statement

The Autogens' biology, culture, and aesthetics all reinforce one idea:

> **Continuity does not require sameness.**

The body survives through mineralization.

The mind survives through distributed neural architecture.

The past survives through the mnemospore.

The individual survives through succession.

But none of these forms of survival are perfect.

The body changes.

The memories become compressed.

The personalities diverge.

The ancestor dies.

The successor is born.

And yet the Autogen can truthfully say:

> **"That was me."**

while also saying:

> **"I am not them."**

That paradox is the central identity of the species.

Strange but Playable

The body can be extremely strange while remaining capable of ordinary character-driven play.

The anatomy retains enough familiar functionality for an Autogen to:

- hold weapons
- use tools
- open doors
- write
- manipulate objects
- operate machinery
- gesture
- walk through an ordinary environment

The guiding principle is:

> **Alien anatomy, familiar personhood.**

An Autogen should still be capable of being an ordinary player character with recognizable motivations, relationships, flaws, and individuality.

Society as a Source of Story

The Autogen lifecycle naturally creates relationships between:

- parents
- children
- siblings
- friends
- elders
- custodians
- successors
- unrelated individuals

The mnemospore and testament create two different forms of inheritance.

The mnemospore preserves part of the elder's past.

The testament influences the successor's future.

This distinction can make continuity, inheritance, family, and individual identity meaningful sources of character and story.

Designer Notes

Biological Rather Than Magical

Whenever possible, unusual capabilities should have a biological explanation.

Alien Anatomy, Familiar Personhood

The body may be extremely strange, but an Autogen should still be capable of being an ordinary player character with recognizable motivations, relationships, flaws, and individuality.

No Mandatory Dwarf Clichés

Do not reintroduce beards, mines, axes, underground living, or similar features merely because they are traditional.

Continuity Without Immortality

Succession preserves meaningful aspects of the individual, but does not create perfect immortality.

Inheritance Without Determinism

Inherited memories and the elder's testament influence the successor without completely determining their personality.

Mineral Does Not Mean Stone

The mineralized body is living biological tissue.

Strange but Playable

The anatomy can be alien, but should still permit ordinary interaction with an environment and other characters.

Society Is Necessary

The lifecycle should generate social relationships rather than making society irrelevant.

The Past Matters, but Fades

Memory inheritance is powerful enough to create genuine continuity but lossy enough that history remains history.

Open Questions Deliberately Left Unresolved

The following are not currently considered necessary to define the species and may be specified later:

- exact molecular mechanism of memory encoding
- exact composition of the ossicles
- detailed vascular anatomy
- exact structure of the lungs
- exact reproductive anatomy
- precise number and arrangement of fingers/toes
- detailed sensory organs
- exact mechanism by which mnemospore information reorganizes the nervous system
- precise age of sexual maturity
- precise age of succession
- exact duration of juvenile development
- exact duration of metamorphosis/hibernation
- exact lifespan
- detailed evolutionary history
- taxonomy beyond the common name "Autogen"

These should remain flexible until the setting requires them.

Design Principles to Preserve

IV.11.1 Biological Rather Than Magical
Whenever possible, unusual capabilities should have a biological explanation.

IV.11.2 Alien Anatomy, Familiar Personhood
The body may be extremely strange, but an Autogen should still be capable of being an ordinary player character with recognizable motivations, relationships, flaws, and individuality.

IV.11.3 No Mandatory Dwarf Clichés
Do not reintroduce beards, mines, axes, underground living, or similar features merely because they are traditional.

IV.11.4 Continuity Without Immortality
Succession preserves meaningful aspects of the individual, but does not create perfect immortality.

IV.11.5 Inheritance Without Determinism
Inherited memories and the elder's testament influence the successor without completely determining their personality.

IV.11.6 Mineral Does Not Mean Stone
The mineralized body is living biological tissue.

IV.11.7 Strange but Playable
The anatomy can be alien, but should still permit ordinary interaction with an environment and other characters.

IV.11.8 Society Is Necessary
The lifecycle should generate social relationships rather than making society irrelevant.

IV.11.9 The Past Matters, but Fades
Memory inheritance is powerful enough to create genuine continuity but lossy enough that history remains history.

Current Canonical Names

Species: Autogen

Plural: Autogens

Memory seed: mnemospore

Bearer of a mnemospore: mnemosporan

These terms are considered **locked in** unless deliberately revisited later.